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Prof. Dr. Alexander Wuttke
Digitalization and Political Behavior, Geschwister-Scholl-Institut für Politikwissenschaft, LMU Munich

17 October 2026

Re: PhD Researcher in Computational Social Science, Emmy Noether Group "Predictably Paradoxical"

Dear Professor Wuttke,

Your migration interviews show that people at the same point on a scale can hold very different mental models, and that voice and chat draw different text out of the same people. Much of my last two years has gone into the second half of that problem in social media: when the medium changes how an opinion is written, can a model's labels still be compared? The position asks for Python and experience orchestrating LLM agents, text-as-data and NLP methods, and an interest in belief systems and democratic attitudes. I bring a methods paper on measuring opinion across platforms, LLM agents and labelling systems that I designed and run in production at M+C Saatchi Fluency and at Artemis AI, the social media start-up I co-founded, and eight years of collecting and analysing large multilingual text. I want to put all of it into mapping how people think about democracy, in a way that holds across modes, languages and countries.

Your work. *AI Conversational Interviewing* (Wuttke, Lang, Klamm, Würschinger and Kreuter, 2026) shows what a battery from the German Longitudinal Election Study cannot: not only where partisans stand on migration, but what comes to mind first, with FDP supporters opening on the labour market and Die Linke supporters on humanitarian concerns. The paper is candid about two things I recognise. Voice answers are longer and more conversational, text answers shorter and denser, with chat replies shrinking after about the tenth turn, so mode comparisons describe systems as deployed rather than a pure modality effect. And about a quarter of survey and interview records could not be linked because respondents typed their IDs by hand. The first is a measurement problem and the second a pipeline problem, and I have spent my working life between the two.

Python and experience working with LLMs. I build LLM systems that act on their own and keep them honest. At Fluency, which analyses social media for global brands and UK government, I designed a self-healing agent: when a forum crawler breaks, Claude works through tools on a server I built, diagnoses the failure, rewrites the code and tests it on the live site before anything ships, while a second agent builds new crawlers; both follow explicit ground rules, with prompt fencing and approval gates, and I decide what merges. At Artemis AI I designed a labelling chain in which Claude labels about 6,000 posts and explains each label, rules mined from those explanations become the prompt for DeepSeek, and its labels train our own classifiers. For our December beta I lead the build of Art-E, an advisor on Amazon Bedrock that answers only from a client's own data, with citations and guardrails. An AI interviewer needs the same things: an agenda, rules it cannot drift from, and a record of every turn.

Text-as-data methods and natural language processing. My MSc dissertation in Data Analytics at the University of Portsmouth (Distinction, Chevening Scholar), supervised by Dr Ella Haig, analysed public reaction to UK economic policy in 255,446 comments from X, Reddit, YouTube and Quora, with a fine-tuned BERT model against BiLSTM and lexicon baselines, calibration, significance tests, and LIME and integrated gradients to see what the model relied on. At Fluency I was an analyst on a twelve-month discourse study of 100,845 Brandwatch and 170,542 Reddit mentions: a BERTopic-derived codebook, LLM tagging with a prompt-version hash on every tag, and three pilot runs on the same 500 rows before the full run, the same LLM-first, human-validated logic your team used to code topics and frames. At Artemis AI I fine-tune XLM-R, DistilBERT and DeBERTa classifiers for toxicity, intent and topic, and we are building evaluation around a human-labelled golden set, so that no model reaches users without being checked against people.

Interest in belief systems and democratic attitudes. My research began with a political question: what does the public think of the policies made in its name, and can online text tell us? The dissertation's weakness taught me most. Its labels were seeded by a lexicon, so its checks were partly circular, and it assumed that a "negative" post means the same on Reddit as on YouTube. With Dr Haig I turned that into *Is the Platform Part of the Measurement?* (arXiv, 2026), which treats each platform as a survey mode and applies generalizability theory, measurement invariance and score linking to machine-labelled opinion. In the simulation I built, pooling platforms at face value gives the wrong sign of aggregate sentiment on nearly a quarter of days. My Chevening application

proposed a cross-platform system to give government evidence of public opinion. What draws me to your group is the step beyond sentiment: not whether people approve, but how their reasons hang together, and which of them survive a follow-up question.

Why social media, and why this matters to me. Social media is the work I care most about, because it is where I learned what online numbers can and cannot say about people. I started as a computer science student in Pakistan collecting web and social data for clients on Fiverr, more than 300 projects; at Dubizzle Labs I built the data behind dashboards on what people discussed across 15 markets in English, Arabic, Urdu and Hindi; at Fluency I turn conversation from ten platforms into reports read by government communications teams; and at Artemis AI, where I lead a team of five, we help creators and businesses understand more than three million comments, with a storm detector for bursts of hostility and filters that stop dialect and banter being read as toxicity. Every one of those jobs hit the same wall: researchers can only hear what people happen to post, in the form each platform encourages. AI interviewing lets the researcher ask the question and still hear people in their own words. That is why I want to do a PhD now, and why in your group.

A question I could contribute to. Before belief systems are compared across modes and your thirteen countries, are the topic and frame labels behind them invariant? If voice yields looser reasoning and chat denser claims, a frame such as causal reasoning may be coded more often in one mode for the same view, and an attitude may look well-founded or superficial partly because of the interviewer system. I would treat mode, language and country as facets, test the coding scheme for invariance and differential item functioning against human-coded subsamples, and only then compare, while making linkage and turn-level logging automatic so that no interview is lost to a typed ID.

What I do not yet bring. I have no degree in political science or psychology, and my political psychology comes from reading, not training. I have not designed a survey or run an experiment with human participants, my agents work through tools rather than talk to people, so I have not yet built a multi-turn interviewer, and I have no peer-reviewed publication. I would close these gaps through the institute's courses and the group's studies from the first month, and start learning German on arrival.

Practicalities. I can start on 1 January 2027 and would relocate to Munich to work on site. As writing samples I attach the arXiv paper, for which I built the simulation and the dissertation case study, and my MSc dissertation, which I wrote alone. My referees are Dr Ella Haig, Associate Professor in AI, University of Portsmouth, my supervisor and co-author (Ella.Haig@port.ac.uk), and Dr Fahad Ahmad, Senior Lecturer, University of Portsmouth, who taught and assessed me on the MSc (Fahad.Ahmad@port.ac.uk). Thank you for considering my application.

Yours sincerely,
Asad Ikram